

FOUR SIGNS

The Lie Isn't Specific Enough Yet

A field guide for your coaching session

WHY THESE FOUR

The lie is the hardest layer in this course to excavate precisely, because it feels like truth rather than a claim that could be examined. These four signs are organized by the stage of your coaching session where each one tends to appear. Each describes a way the session can stall on something true in a general sense, but not yet true in the specific sense that belongs only to this character, from this wound.

STAGE 1 · ESTABLISHING THE DISTINCTION

O1 Describing the World, Not the Self

What you've found is still oriented outward — a claim about how people or circumstances behave, not a verdict about the character. That is the hidden truth, restated. The lie is always a self-verdict.

"People can't be trusted."

PUSH Given that this is how the world works, what does your character conclude about themselves? Keep asking until the sentence is about her, not about people.

STAGE 2 · FINDING THE LIE

O2 Generic Enough to Belong to Anyone

The lie could belong to a hundred different characters from a hundred different wounds. It hasn't been calibrated to this specific history yet.

"I'm not enough."

PUSH Would someone who knew this exact wound recognize this sentence as inevitable? If it could describe a dozen other protagonists, it isn't precise enough yet.

STAGE 3 · THE THREE FORMS TEST

03

A Belief That Could Simply Be Talked Out Of

What you've found reads like a mistaken opinion — the kind of thing a character could discard given good enough evidence. The real lie is not an opinion the character holds. It's a structure they stand on.

"Maybe I'm wrong about that."

PUSH Look for the belief that survives contrary evidence and plain willpower — the thing your character still can't shake even when they know better.

STAGE 4 · THE WOUND-TO-LIE LOCK

04

A Connection That Needs an Argument

Completing "Because of this wound, my character concluded ____" requires explanation, reasoning, or an "and therefore" bridge. A lock that needs defending isn't tight.

"Because of the wound, and given her personality, and considering the timing, she probably concluded..."

PUSH The real lie requires no argument from the wound. Show the wound. The lie should be immediate.

THE PASSING EXAMPLE

Return to the character from Resource 2: love conditional on usefulness, invisible the moment she stopped being useful. Her identity statement — "I have no intrinsic worth. My value exists only in what I do for others" — against all four signs:

01 · Self, not world

Passes. The sentence is entirely about her, not about what people are like.

02 · Specific, not generic

Passes. Tied to a value system built specifically on usefulness — not a floating sense of inadequacy anyone could feel.

03 · Tenacious, not optional

Passes. She can be shown affection freely given and still not believe she deserves it — evidence alone doesn't move it.

04 · Locked, not argued

Passes. "Because love was conditional on her usefulness, she concluded she has no intrinsic worth" needs no bridge. It's immediate.

That is what a finished lie looks like: a sentence your character has never once heard spoken aloud, that nonetheless explains everything they do.

WHAT COMES NEXT — LESSON 5

The lie you've now stated precisely creates something in your character: a want. Lesson 5, The Want vs. Need, is where that want gets tested against what your character actually needs instead — the gap between the two is your story's engine.